

Episode 47: Once Upon a Time... (29) – OVA Days Begin! *Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal*

Over the weekend, I went to Hong Kong for delicious seafood with friends who live in Beijing. ...Writing it like that sounds incredibly international and celebrity-like, doesn't it? (laugh) Well anyway, I went to Hong Kong in a rush.

This was my first overseas trip since my Seoul business trip last year, so it's been a year. For private travel, it's been two years, and that was also Hong Kong. This time, the couple I met up with are both fluent in Chinese, so the food ordering was absolutely perfect and wonderfully impressive!

Hong Kong after two years seemed even more overflowing with Japanese products. Street signs, supermarket shelves—everything that caught the eye was made in Japan. While this tendency existed before, it felt like it had accelerated even more in these two years (so souvenirs for staff were really difficult... (sweat)).

"This is China and yet not China" were the words of the couple from Beijing. Hong Kong people's public manners are better than Tokyo's. According to the couple living in Beijing, Beijing still has a long way to go in that regard.

Also, while Hong Kong used to be a paradise for pirated DVDs of Japanese anime, now all such items have completely disappeared from storefronts—or rather, entire stores have disappeared (laugh)—and only proper legitimate versions are being sold. Well, Beijing apparently still remains a pirated version paradise (bitter laugh).

"China doesn't change quickly in anything" are the words of Jackie Chan (成龍). Not just manners, but the Chinese people's awareness regarding copyright and their low cultural standards still seem far from improvement.

Well then.

The story jumps way back to around 1989-1990.

The TV series *Saint Seiya* ended (the "Showa" era also ended and became "Heisei" around this time), followed by *Akuma-kun*, *Mo-retsū A-Taro*, and then *Kingyo Chuiho* (きんぎょ注意報)—I continued to handle the main colour settings for TV Asahi's Saturday 7 PM slot.

The flow was: deciding main character colours, creating colouring settings, determining processing rules for special characters (like the transparency level of "Yurei Oyaji" in *A-Taro*), and handling colour direction for the opening, ending, and first episode. As I wrote earlier, there was still no concept, position, or credit for "colour design" at this time, so my "traces" only barely remain as a name in the "Finishing" section of the first episode's ending credits (bitter laugh).

Oh, I also got to participate in the first theatrical version of *Akuma-kun*...

Around this time, from the late 1980s to early 1990s, anime works for sell-through and rental video were growing rapidly, and I gradually transitioned to working on those so-called OVA productions.

Toei at this time had two pillar OVA series: *BE-BOP HIGHSCHOOL* and *Shonan Bakusozoku* (湘南爆走族), plus expanding series like *Yankee Reppuu-tai* (ヤンキー烈風隊) and *Crying Freeman*. They were also producing many more detailed video works.

Actually, I was dying to work on OVA productions (laugh). TV works were fun in their own way, but the system was becoming one where I couldn't directly do colour direction myself, and I was wanting to challenge denser animation work and content for slightly older age groups.

Also, there was the paint problem. As I wrote long ago, TV works had restrictions on the number of paint colours we could use. STAC paints already had few colours. But with OVAs, I could freely use paint colours other than TV-use paints (laugh).

The first production I got to participate in was *Hana no Asuka-gumi! 2: Lonely Cats Battle Royal* (花のあすか組！ 2 ロンリーキャッツ・バトルロイヤル). Director Umezawa Yoshitoshi, animation director Motohashi Hideyuki, art director Nakamura Mitsuki. It was an OVA side story (?) of the manga "Hana no Asuka-gumi!" by Takaguchi Satosumi. "Asuka-gumi!" had been made into a popular live-action film by Kadokawa a few years earlier. This was the second OVA. October 1989.

So I went to greet director Umezawa saying "Please take care of me!" Director Umezawa's first words were "Tsujita-kun, you can do whatever you want!" (sweat). Furthermore, "But you know, there's absolutely none—schedule!!" (explosion).

I was happy to be entrusted with an OVA work and wasn't thinking about scheduling at all, but this *Asuka-gumi!* was actually a production scheduled for delivery by year's end. "Huh? It's October now, right? (sweat)" I said. Ah, I realised then that a pattern of "difficult content and no-schedule projects go to Tsujita" had begun around that time, and this *Asuka-gumi!* OVA was the same! (bitter laugh)

That very week, we did character test colouring. This time too, I think art director Nakamura-san initially provided the character specifications. Along with that, I also presented various colours I'd thought up for comparison. The characters were based on original creator Takaguchi-san's drawings, refined by Motohashi-san, and while the line density was clean, they were sharp and keen with a wonderfully adult atmosphere that made me happy (laugh).

It's interesting how, while deciding the basic normal colours, plans for various scene colour changes for the main story keep bubbling up in my mind. This is different from deciding main colours for TV series productions. I could control all these characters and colours myself.

"Yeah. Let's go with this feeling!" Umezawa-san gave the OK, and the base colours were decided. That was the beginning of turbulent days.

(08.04.15)